



NGO CONG BINH, a barber in Ho Chi Minh City, works on a customer. Vietnam’s Chicano “movement” began 10 years ago.

COLUMN ONE

Where Chicano meets Vietnamese

Mexican American culture finds a *familia* in Southeast Asia, where barbers and tattoo artists are creating a community with purpose

By Stephanie Yang | REPORTING FROM HO CHI MINH CITY

When Nguyen Phuoc Loc started dabbling in Chicano culture eight years ago, it was simply because he liked the way that the loose clothing offset his large head.

Today, he considers himself Chicano through and through. The 30-year-old Vietnamese barber has never been to the United States. Yet he has filled his life and work with tributes to Mexican American identity and culture.

The back of the barbershop he manages features a mural of the Virgen de Guadalupe, a cactus plant and a Mexican flag. Sneakers hang by their laces from barbed wire, dangling above two motorbikes.

Even his shaved head is covered in the Gothic black letters long popular in Chicano culture that spell out: Family, Loyalty, L.A. The ink on his crown — a large number 6 — signifies his status as the sixth member of a small but increasingly visible community: a local band of barbers and tattoo artists who call themselves Viet Chicanos.

“In the beginning, I was just copying the older guys, their style and all,” said Loc, 30. “But over time, I started to feel that it really fit who I am. It happened gradually, like it seeped into me.”

Fashion aside, the culture has given Loc a sense of belonging, and motivation to work harder at his craft. He began watching movies steeped in Chicano culture, such as “American [See Fusion, A4]

FEMA urged to reinstate state’s quake grants

Lives will be at risk if the canceled retrofit funds aren’t provided, Sen. Adam Schiff says.

By RONG-GONG LIN II

The Trump administration has canceled \$33 million worth of federal funds meant to help pay for earthquake retrofits in California — sparking “grave concern” and a call to reconsider from one of the state’s highest elected officials.

In a letter last week, Sen. Adam Schiff (D-Calif.) urged U.S. Homeland Security Secretary Kristi Noem to reinstate the funds, which would’ve been used to strengthen between 750 and 1,500 apartment buildings.

“In California, earthquakes are not a question of if, but when,” Schiff wrote in his letter, addressed to both Noem and David Richardson, a senior official performing the duties of the FEMA administrator. “This move must be reversed before tragedy strikes next.”

The Earthquake Multi-Unit Soft-Story Retrofit grants — originally greenlighted through the Federal Emergency Management Agency, which is part of Noem’s department — were meant to help retrofit the kind of vulnerable apartment buildings that crushed people to death when they collapsed during previous major urban earthquakes.

These types of apartment buildings are ubiquitous across California’s major cities. They have flimsy supports on the ground story that prop up carports, garages or storefronts and can snap when shaken from side to side in an earthquake.

FEMA issued a statement on April 4 announcing the cancellation of the Building Resilient Infrastructure and Communities program, known as BRIC, which would have funded the California earthquake retrofits.

“The BRIC program was yet another example of a wasteful and ineffective FEMA program. It was more [See Grants, A8]



DEYSI Vargas with her 4-year-old daughter, who needs IV feedings to stay alive.

Girl who is facing deportation requires lifesaving care in U.S.

Family granted humanitarian entry loses legal status

By ANDREA CASTILLO

Deysi Vargas’ daughter was nearly 2½ when she took her first steps.

The girl was a year delayed because she had spent most of her short life in a hospital in Playa del Carmen, Mexico, tethered to

feeding tubes 24 hours a day. She has short bowel syndrome, a rare condition that prevents her body from completely absorbing the nutrients of regular food.

Vargas and her husband were desperate to get their daughter, whom The Times is identifying by her initials, S.G.V., better medical care.

In 2023, they received temporary humanitarian permission to enter the U.S. legally through Tijuana.

Now in Bakersfield, the family received notice last month that their legal status had been terminated. The letter warned them: “It is in your best interest to avoid [See Girl, A12]

Data show deeper water losses

As reservoirs fall, the Colorado River Basin is also being emptied of groundwater at a rate called ‘alarming.’

By IAN JAMES

As the Colorado River’s giant reservoirs have declined during the last two decades, even larger amounts of water have been pumped and drained from underground, according to new research based on data from NASA satellites.

Scientists at Arizona State University examined more than two decades of satellite measurements and found that since 2003 the quantity of groundwater depleted in the Colorado River Basin is comparable to the total capacity of Lake Mead, the nation’s largest reservoir.

The researchers estimated that pumping from wells has drained about 34 cubic kilometers, or 28 million acre-feet, of groundwater in the watershed since 2003 — more than twice the amount of water that has been depleted from the river’s reservoirs during that time.

“The Colorado River Basin is losing groundwater at an alarming rate,” said Kareem Abdelmohsen, the lead author and a researcher at ASU’s School of Sustainability.

The losses are being driven largely by heavy pumping to supply agriculture, he said. At the same time, prolonged drought and rising [See Groundwater, A10]

For some, medical debt will disappear

Los Angeles County is paying off millions owed by its residents. Do you qualify?

By KAREN GARCIA

Did you get a letter in the mail from the County of Los Angeles with the word “Undue” in bold blue? It’s not a scam. It’s a notification that your medical debt was cleared by the county.

More than 134,000 L.A. County residents recently began getting notices in the mail as part of the first wave of medical bill forgiveness made possible by the county’s Medical Debt Relief Program. The first round of notices is expected to relieve more than \$183 million in debt.

The program was launched, in partnership with the nonprofit Undue Medical Debt, in December with the mission of providing financial relief for eligible residents by purchasing and eliminating the debt. The funds for the program were made possible by an initial \$5-million investment ap- [See Debt, A12]

A solemn pause for the fallen

On Memorial Day, gatherings honor those who sacrificed for the country. CALIFORNIA, B1

‘Rust’ armorer is freed from prison

Hannah Gutierrez served 14 months for the death of Halyna Hutchins. BUSINESS, A9

They speak well for the Angels

Randazzo and Gubicza are well paired in the broadcast booth, writes Bill Shaikin. SPORTS, B10

Weather

Low clouds, then sun. L.A. Basin: 77/60. B6

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